Decision tree

Off-plan handover: which option is yours?

Stage payment due. Cash tight. Four options, three decision questions, and the documents each path requires. Built for landlords with one or more off-plan units approaching handover in 6–12 months.

The three questions

Before choosing a path, answer all three. The combination of answers points to the right option.

Question 1 — How much time until handover?

≥ 6 months: all four options remain open.

3–6 months: refinancing and developer renegotiation still feasible if you start today.

< 3 months: secondary-market sale or own-cash completion are the only realistic options.

Question 2 — Would you buy this property today at contract price?

Yes, with conviction: completing (own funds or refinancing) is the right path.

Yes, but reluctantly: refinancing is the cleanest exit if you can support the mortgage cashflow.

No: secondary-market sale, even at a discount, is preferable to completing into a loss.

Question 3 — Do you have non-property capital you'd otherwise invest at <8% return?

Yes: completing with your own funds is rational if the asset will earn >8% IRR over your hold.

No: refinancing is the path. Don't liquidate productive assets to complete.

The four options

Pick one based on your three answers above.

01 — Complete with your own funds

When: Time: any. Conviction: high. Alt-capital return: <8%.

Process: Release cash, transfer to developer escrow on the schedule in your SPA, attend handover.

Timing: 2–6 weeks from cash availability.

Documents needed: SPA + signed addenda · stage payment receipts to date · proof of source of funds (UAE: bank statements + AML disclosure)

Risks: Opportunity cost: capital tied up. If market softens post-handover, you absorb the move.

02 — Refinance — secure handover finance

When: Time: ≥3 months. Conviction: yes (with or without enthusiasm). Cashflow supports a mortgage.

Process: Apply 8–12 weeks before handover. Bank does valuation, processes income docs, issues offer, draws down at handover.

Timing: 8–12 weeks application to drawdown. Start now if handover is in 90+ days.

Documents needed: SPA · stage payments to date · panel-valuer valuation · 6 months bank statements · employment letter / business income proof · global asset declaration · developer NOC · existing mortgage statements (if any)

Risks: Valuation below contract price means you fund the gap in cash. Mortgage rates on off-plan handover finance run 30–60bps higher than completed-unit rates.

03 — Sell on the secondary market pre-handover

When: Time: any but ideally 60–120 days before handover. Conviction: low or absent. Cashflow won't support a mortgage.

Process: List with an agent specialising in off-plan resales, agree price with buyer, transfer at developer-issued NOC + relevant land registry step.

Timing: 8–12 weeks listing to settlement in most markets.

Documents needed: SPA · stage payment receipts · developer NOC · seller-side agency engagement letter · land department forms (varies by market)

Risks: In soft markets, expect 5–20% below contract price. Selling 4–6 months out usually nets less than waiting until 60 days out, when value acceleration is steepest.

04 — Negotiate with the developer

When: Time: anytime. Used to buy more time, not as a primary exit.

Process: Direct call to the developer's in-house finance or senior sales team. Request: stage-payment extension, payment schedule restructuring, or stage waiver against a small premium.

Timing: 2–6 weeks to a written agreement.

Documents needed: Original SPA · current account statement with developer · any prior correspondence · proposed revised payment schedule

Risks: Verbal agreements vanish when sales staff turn over. Get everything on developer letterhead, signed by an authorised signatory.

Common mistakes

What we see when landlords get stuck.

Waiting. Hoping the market recovers in the 60 days before handover. It sometimes does. Usually it doesn't. The cost of starting refinancing 12 weeks before handover is small. The cost of not having an option at handover is unbounded.

Single-path planning. Picking one option and ignoring the others. Always model all four. The exercise of writing them out forces clarity.

Counting on the developer's flexibility without confirming. Renegotiation is real but inconsistent. Make the call early, get the answer in writing, and have option 1, 2, or 3 ready as a backup.

Underestimating the bank valuation gap. In a soft market, off-plan units often value below contract. Get a desktop valuation 4 months out so you know what cash gap you're funding.

How AssetCentral helps

What's modelled in the product.

The off-plan handover module models all four options in parallel: cashflow impact under each path, NPV at the discount rate you set, document checklists that auto-generate based on your asset's jurisdiction, and alerts triggered 90 and 60 days before handover. If you have multiple off-plan units, it sequences them by handover date and highlights months where two stage payments collide.

Start your free 14-day trial at assetcentral.ai/signup — no credit card required. Add your off-plan unit in 3 minutes; the planner gives you a costed action list within 60 seconds.